Present tenses and modal verbs for opinions

Understand it

Present simple describes general truths and habits, which is why it is the main tense of opinion essays: Technology changes how we work. Present continuous describes temporary or current trends: More people are working from home.

Modal verbs show how strongly you mean something. A band 7 essay does not say everything with must: it chooses the right strength for each idea, and softens claims that cannot be proved.

The rules

- Present simple: facts, general truths and habits: Education improves job prospects.
- Present continuous: changes happening now: More people are working from home.
- Modals show how sure or how strong you are: must (very strong), should (advice), can, could, may, might (possible).
- Hedging makes an opinion careful and academic: tends to, is likely to, may lead to, it seems that.

All the words and forms you need

Very strong (duty)	must · have to · need to · it is essential that
Advice	should · ought to · had better · it would be wise to
Possibility	can · could · may · might
Opinion openers	I believe · I would argue · In my view · It seems to me that · I am convinced that
Present simple signals	always · usually · generally · nowadays (with continuous: currently · increasingly)

Where you use it

Writing: Use should and must for solutions; may and might for results you are not sure of.

Speaking: Use I would say, I tend to, and probably to avoid sounding too absolute.

Reading: Words like may, might and could mean the writer is not certain: this matters in True / False / Not Given.

More examples

- I believe that governments should fund public libraries.
- Children who read every day generally do better at school.
- More students are choosing online degrees than ever before.
- Parents must teach children how to use money.
- Social media may affect young people's self-esteem.

- In my view, schools ought to teach practical skills.

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ He go to school by bus.	✓ He goes to school by bus.
✗ People are agree with this.	✓ People agree with this.
✗ Governments must to act.	✓ Governments must act.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Do you think children should have phones? Why?
2. What are young people in your country doing more often these days?
3. What must a good teacher do?
4. What might happen to newspapers in the future?
5. What do you usually do at weekends?

Writing practice

Write an introduction (2 sentences) for: Some people think university should be free. Do you agree? Use present simple and one modal verb.

Practice

1. Choose: Students (study / are studying) more online nowadays.

2. Choose: Water (boils / is boiling) at 100 degrees.

3. Add a modal of advice: Schools ___ teach money skills.

4. Make it less certain: Technology will destroy jobs.

5. Correct: Children should to learn two languages.

6. Correct: Many people is worried about prices.

Answers

1. are studying
2. boils
3. should
4. Technology may destroy jobs.
5. Children should learn two languages.
6. Many people are worried about prices.